

ENGLISH

ODE TO A NIGHTINGALE (By John Keats)

HSSE01-A

My heart aches, and a drowsy numbness pains
 My sense, as though of hemlock I had drunk,
 Or emptied some dull opiate to the drains
 One minute past, and Lethe-wards had sunk:
 'Tis not through envy of thy happy lot,
 But being too happy in thine happiness,—
 That thou, light-winged Dryad of the trees
 In some melodious plot
 Of beechen green, and shadows numberless,
 Singest of summer in full-throated ease.
 O, for a draught of vintage! that hath been
 Cool'd a long age in the deep-delved earth,
 Tasting of Flora and the country green,
 Dance, and Provençal song, and sunburnt mirth!
 O for a beaker full of the warm South,
 Full of the true, the blushful Hippocrene,
 With beaded bubbles winking at the brim,
 And purple-stained mouth;
 That I might drink, and leave the world unseen,
 And with thee fade away into the forest dim:
 Fade far away, dissolve, and quite forget
 What thou among the leaves hast never known,
 The weariness, the fever, and the fret
 Here, where men sit and hear each other groan;
 Where palsy shakes a few, sad, last gray hairs,
 Where youth grows pale, and spectre-thin, and dies;
 Where but to think is to be full of sorrow
 And leaden-eyed despairs,
 Where Beauty cannot keep her lustrous eyes,
 Or new Love pine at them beyond to-morrow.
 Away! away! for I will fly to thee,
 Not charioted by Bacchus and his pards,
 But on the viewless wings of Poesy,
 Though the dull brain perplexes and retards:
 Already with thee! tender is the night,
 And haply the Queen-Moon is on her throne,
 Cluster'd around by all her starry Fays;
 But here there is no light,
 Save what from heaven is with the breezes blown
 Through verdurous glooms and winding mossy ways.
 I cannot see what flowers are at my feet,
 Nor what soft incense hangs upon the boughs,
 But, in embalmed darkness, guess each sweet
 Wherewith the seasonable month endows
 The grass, the thicket, and the fruit-tree wild;
 White hawthorn, and the pastoral eglantine;
 Fast fading violets cover'd up in leaves;
 And mid-May's eldest child,
 The coming musk-rose, full of dewy wine,
 The murmurous haunt of flies on summer eves.
 Darkling I listen; and, for many a time
 I have been half in love with easeful Death,

Call'd him soft names in many a mused rhyme,
 To take into the air my quiet breath;
 Now more than ever seems it rich to die,
 To cease upon the midnight with no pain,
 While thou art pouring forth thy soul abroad
 In such an ecstasy!
 Still wouldst thou sing, and I have ears in vain—
 To thy high requiem become a sod.
 Thou wast not born for death, immortal Bird!
 No hungry generations tread thee down;
 The voice I hear this passing night was heard
 In ancient days by emperor and clown:
 Perhaps the self-same song that found a path
 Through the sad heart of Ruth, when, sick for home,
 She stood in tears amid the alien corn;
 The same that oft-times hath
 Charm'd magic casements, opening on the foam
 Of perilous seas, in faery lands forlorn.
 Forlorn! the very word is like a bell
 To toll me back from thee to my sole self!
 Adieu! the fancy cannot cheat so well
 As she is fam'd to do, deceiving elf.
 Adieu! adieu! thy plaintive anthem fades
 Past the near meadows, over the still stream,
 Up the hill-side; and now 'tis buried deep
 In the next valley-glades:
 Was it a vision, or a waking dream?
 Fled is that music:—Do I wake or sleep?

General

- Born : 31 October 1795, Moorgate, London, England
- Died : 23 February 1821 (aged 25) Rome, Papal States.
- Engaged with Fanny Brown
- Parents : Thomas and Frances Keats
- He was the eldest of four surviving children

Works

- Literary Movement : Romanticism (Second Generation)
- First Written Poem : 'Imitation of Spenser' and 'On Peace' (1814)
- First Published Poem: O Solitude! in Leigh Hunt's The Examiner (1816)
- One Play in Verse: Otho the Great: A Tragedy in Five Acts (with his friend Charles Brown)
- Most Criticised Poem: Endymion (Blackwood and Quarterly)
- Most Celebrated Poems: 6 Odes
- Annus Mirabilis: 1819
- Critical Term: Negative capability
- Hellenism: Description of Greek Art and Culture
- Synesthesia : In literature when one sense is used to describe another.

Death

- Cause of death : Tuberculosis
- Epitaph : Here lies One Whose Name was writ in Water
- Adonais : A pastoral elegy by Shelley for lamenting the death of John Keats in 1821
- Adonais is the god of fertility

Negative Capability

- From letter to George and Thomas Keats, 21st December 1817.
- 'I had not a dispute but a disquisition with Dilkey, on various subjects; several things dovetailed in my mind, and at once it struck me **what quality went to form a Man of Achievement**, especially in literature, and which Shakespeare possessed so enormously I mean 'negative capability', that is, when man is capable of being in uncertainties mysteries, doubts, without any irritable reaching after fact and reason.

Cockney School of Poetry

- Cockney is a local dialect - Nonstandard- lower class- working class dialect of people live in south part of London
- Leigh Hunt, William Hazlitt, John Keats and P.B. Shelley are listed under this title
- All the writers lack the sophistication and noble diction in their writing
- Percy Bysshe Shelley was accused of being similarly offensive politically, but the reviewers excused him for his genius (and, of course, his high birth).
- An attack on the class background of the authors and their aspirations to the highest level of the education
- A reaction to the “Cockney” politics of the authors.
- Democratic ideology of Hunt and Hazlitt were offensive to the Blackwood’s review staff
- On Cockney school of poetry - John Gibson Lockhart essay in Blackwood Magazine on August 1818.

What Is an Ode?

- An ode is a short lyric poem that praises an individual, an idea, or an event.
- In ancient Greece, odes were originally accompanied by music—in fact, the word “ode” comes from the Greek word aeidein, which means to sing or to chant.
- Odes are often ceremonial, and formal in tone. - There are several different types of odes, but they are all highly structured and adhere to poetic forms.
- The English Romantic poets wrote many odes, all of which explored intense emotions.
- While Romantic odes deviate in form and meter from the traditional Greek ode, they all tend to follow some kind of traditional verse structure.

Facts about the Poem Ode to a Nightingale

- First published in Annals of the Fine Arts the following July 1819
 - Benjamin Haydon was given a copy of “Ode to a Nightingale”
 - He shared the poem with the editor, James Elmes. Elmes of the Magazine
- It was written in Hampstead, London
 - The garden of the Spaniards Inn
 - Under a plum tree in the garden of Keats’ house at Wentworth Place (Charles Armitage Brown whom with Keats shared the house)
 - “In the spring of 1819, a nightingale had built her nest near my house. Keats felt a tranquil and continual joy in her song; and one morning he took his chair from the breakfast-table to the grass-plot under a plum-tree, where he sat for two or three hours. When he came into the house, I perceived he had some scraps of paper in his hand, and these he was quietly thrusting behind the books. On inquiry, I found those scraps, four or five in number, contained his poetic feelings on the song of the nightingale.” - Charles Brown
- Keats dated this poem as ‘May 1819’
- The poem is told in the first-person
 - The speaker speaks to the nightingale through apostrophe.

Form, Metre & Rhyme

- Ode: The word “ode” itself is of Greek origin, meaning “sung”
- Stanzas: 8 (10 lines in each) - the longest of his odes.
- Metre : Mostly in Iambic Pentameter: My sense, | as though | of hem- | lock I | had drunk
- Metrical Variations: My heart | aches, and | a drow- | sy numb- | ness pains (2nd is Trochee)
- Rhyme Scheme: ABAB CDE CDE

Vocabulary

- **Hemlock** (Line 2) - Hemlock is a poisonous plant, famously ingested by Socrates as a means of committing suicide.
- **Opiate** (Line 3) - A drug from the opioid family, which includes heroin and morphine.
- **Lethe-wards** (Line 4) - Towards Lethe. Lethe is a river in the Greek mythological underworld. Drinking its waters obliterates the drinker’s mind, making them forget their identity.
- **Thy/thine** (Line 5, Line 6) - Archaic form of “your.”
- **Lot** (Line 5) - Another word for situation/life experiences, referring to the nightingale and contrasting with the “wear[y]” lot of humankind.
- **Thou** (Line 7) - An archaic form of “you.”
- **Light-winged Dryad** (Line 7) - A dryad is a tree nymph. They are usually female and human in appear-

ance; they guard the forest and are notoriously elusive (like the nightingale).

- **Beechen green** (Line 9) - A green patch of land surrounded by beech trees.
- **Draught of vintage** (Line 11) - A drink of vintage wine.
- **Hath** (Line 11) - Has.
- **Deep-delved** (Line 12) - This refers to the vintage wine being cooled and stored in the depths of the earth (an exaggeration of storing wine in a cellar).
- **Flora** (Line 13) - Flora is a Roman goddess of plants and flowers.
- **Provençal** (Line 14) - An adjective denoting that something is from Provence, a temperate region of south-eastern France. As with many other parts of France, it's renowned for its wine!
- **Mirth** (Line 14) - Cheerful amusement. **Beaker** (Line 15) - A glass.
- **The warm South** (Line 15) - Probably extending the earlier reference to Provence to other areas in southern Europe—for example, Greece (where the “Hippocrene” is situated).
- **Hippocrene** (Line 16) - Another (Greek) mythological water source. Drinking from the Hippocrene spring is said to grant the drinker poetic inspiration.
- **Fret** (Line 23) - Worry.
- **Palsy** (Line 25) - Paralysis.
- **Spectre** (Line 26) - A ghost.
- **Leadened eyes** (Line 28) - Eyes heavy with depression and worry.
- **Bacchus and his pards** (Line 32) - Bacchus, a.k.a Dionysus, is the Greek god of wine and revelry. He is sometimes depicted riding a chariot pulled by leopards.
- **Poesy** (Line 33) - Poetry.
- **Retards** (Line 34) - Makes slow.
- **Starry fays** (Line 37) - The stars, here depicted as fairies.
- **Verdurous** (Line 40) - Green and luscious.
- **Embalmed darkness** (Line 43) - The surrounding darkness which covers everything.
- **Seasonable** (Line 44) - Relating to the turning of the seasons, but also meaning timely.
- **Hawthorn/Eglantine/Violets/Musk-rose** (Line 46, Line 47, Line 49) - Various beautiful flowers with pleasant fragrances.
- **Murmurous** (Line 50) - This means the flies collectively make a low-sounding noise.
- **Darkling** (Line 51) - Darkening, probably relating to the speaker's mood. This can also be a noun referring to something that is characterized by darkness.
- **Easeful** (Line 52) - Restful and quiet.
- **A mused rhyme** (Line 53) - Partly relating to poetic inspiration from the muses, but also possibly a pun on the word “amused”—as though the speaker knows that these verses about death are somewhat naive.
- **Abroad** (Line 57) - Far away, as if in a different land.
- **Ectasy** (Line 58) - Extreme joy or bliss.
- **High requiem** (Line 60) - A requiem is a piece of music that remembers the dead (or an individual who has died). “High” works both as suggesting the quality of the nightingale's song and the fact the bird sings high up in the trees.
- **Sod** (Line 60) - A piece of the ground.
- **Ruth** (Line 66) - A character from the Bible. She was widowed, and chose to take care of her mother-in-law rather than return to her hometown. (Elimelech & Naomi, their sons: Mahlon and Chilion) (Moabite women: Orpah and Ruth) Ruth: “where you go I will go, and where you lodge I will lodge. Your people shall be my people, and your God my God. Where you die I will die, and there will I be buried.”
- **Alien corn** (Line 67) - A field of corn, alien because it is in a foreign land (not the place where Ruth comes from).
- **Often-times** (Line 68) - Often.
- **Casements** (Line 69) - Windows.
- **Forlorn** (Line 70, Line 71) - Mournful and depressed.
- **Adieu** (Line 73, Line 75) - Goodbye.
- **Fancy** (Line 73) - The human imagination.
- **Plaintive anthem** (Line 75) - Sad and mournful music. “Anthem” also works because the nightingale's song is a symbol of its identity, like a national anthem for a country.
- **Valley-glades** (Line 78) - The next fields along, which are hilly.

Poetic Devices and Technique

- **ALLITERATION** : The repetition of consonant sounds at the beginning of words or stressed syllables
- **ALLUSION** : An allusion in a poem refers to a person, place, historical event, or ancient source such as the Bible, mythology, ancient poets etc.

- Line 4: "Lethe": A river in the Greek mythological underworld. Drinking from this river would cause forgetfulness or oblivion in the mind of the drinker
- Line 7: "Dryad": **dryad**, also called **hamadryad**, in Greek mythology, a nymph or nature spirit who lives in trees and takes the form of a beautiful young woman.
- Line 13: "Flora": Flora (Latin: FLMra) is a Roman goddess of flowers and of the season of spring.
- Line 16: "Hippocrene": which is a mythological stream that grants poetic inspiration to those who drink its waters
- Line 32: "Not charioted by Bacchus and his pards": Bacchus was the Roman god of wine and his chariot packed with wine jugs is drawn by two leopards.
- Lines 66: "Through the sad heart of Ruth, when, sick for home": A character from the Bible (Old Testament: Book of Ruth). She was widowed, and chose to take care of her mother-in-law rather than return to her hometown.
- **APOSTROPHE** : In poetry, an apostrophe is a figure of speech in which the poet addresses an absent person, an abstract idea, or a thing.
 - Lines 5-10: "'Tis not through envy of thy happy lot, / But being too happy in thine happiness, — / That thou, light-winged Dryad of the trees / In some melodious plot / Of beechen green, and shadows numberless, / Singest of summer in full-throated ease."
 - Line 20: "And with thee fade away into the forest dim:"
 - Line 31: "Away! away! for I will fly to thee,"
 - Lines 55-60: "Now more than ever seems it rich to die, / To cease upon the midnight with no pain, / While thou art pouring forth thy soul abroad / In such an ecstasy! / Still wouldst thou sing, and I have ears in vain— / To thy high requiem become a sod."
 - Line 61: "Thou wast not born for death, immortal Bird!"
 - Line 62: "No hungry generations tread thee down;"
 - Lines 73-75: "Adieu! the fancy cannot cheat so well / As she is fam'd to do, deceiving elf. / Adieu! adieu! thy plaintive anthem fades"
- **CAESURA** : A stop or pause in a metrical line, often marked by punctuation or by a grammatical boundary, such as a phrase or clause.
- **ENJAMBMENT** : Enjambment is the continuation of a sentence or clause across a line break.
- **HYPERBOLE** : Hyperbole is the use of over-exaggeration to create emphasis
 - Line 61: "immortal Bird"
- **PARADOX**: It is a statement that appears at first to be contradictory, but upon reflection then makes sense.
 - Lines 5-6: "'Tis not through envy of thy happy lot, / But being too happy in thine happiness,"
- **PERSONIFICATION**: Personification is a poetic device where animals, plants or even inanimate objects, are given human qualities
 - Lines 5-10: "'Tis not through envy of thy happy lot, / But being too happy in thine happiness, — / That thou, light-winged Dryad of the trees / In some melodious plot / Of beechen green, and shadows numberless, / Singest of summer in full-throated ease."
 - Lines 29-30: "lustrous eyes, / to-morrow."
 - Lines 36-37: "And haply the Queen-Moon is on her throne / Cluster'd around by all her starry Fays;"
 - Lines 51-54: "and, for many a time / I have been half in love with easeful Death, / Call'd him soft names in many a mused rhyme, / To take into the air my quiet breath;"
- **RHETORICAL QUESTION**: A rhetorical question is asked just for effect, or to lay emphasis on some point being discussed, when no real answer is expected.
 - Lines 79-80: "Was it a vision, or a waking dream? / Fled is that music:—Do I wake or sleep?"
- **SIMILE** : A literary term where you use "like" or "as" to compare two different things and show a common quality between them.
 - Lines 1-4: "My heart aches, and a drowsy numbness pains / My sense, as though of hemlock I had drunk, / Or emptied some dull opiate to the drains / One minute past, and Lethe-wards had sunk:"
 - Lines 71-72: "Forlorn! the very word is like a bell / To toll me back from thee to my sole self!"
- **Polysyndeton** : Polysyndeton is the repeated use of coordinating conjunctions to connect different items in a sentence. (The repetition of conjunctions like and, but, or, nor)
 - Lines - 26: "Where youth grows pale, and spectre-thin, and dies"

MCQS

1. Keats belongs to which literary age?
 - Romantic Age
2. John Keats died of

- Tuberculosis
3. John Keats died at the age of
- 25
4. What is Hellenism that we find in Keats' Poetry
- Description of Greek art and Culture
5. How many odes did Keats Write?
- Six
6. Where did Keats write his famous odes?
- The Wentworth House
7. When did Keats write his five of six famous odes?
- Spring of 1819
8. Ode to a Nightingale was written in
- 1819
9. In which magazine the poem was first Published
- Annals of the Fine Arts
10. It was while Keats heard the song of a nightingale, which inspired the Ode
- Spring
11. Who calls Keats "One of the inheritors of unfulfilled renown?"
- Shelley
12. Who wrote a famous Pastoral Elegy on the death of Keats?
- Shelley - Adonais
13. "Where youth grows pale, spectre-thin, and dies" - refers to
- His brother's death by consumption
14. Escapism can be noticed in Keats' works
- Ode to Nightingale
15. She stood in tears amid the alien corn - the alien corn refers to
- Jerusalem
16. Called him soft names in many a mused rhyme - here he refers to
- Death
17. The poem was composed in
- Spring of 1819
18. O, for a draught of here Keats longs for
- Wine
19. This poem contains stanzas
- 8
20. Hyppocrene is the name of a/an
- Fountain
21. Flora is the Goddess of
- Flower
22. And with thee fade away into the forest
- Dim
23. I have been half in love with Death
- Easeful
24. That hath been / cold a long age' Here the poet speaks of
- Wine
25. I cannot see what flowers are
- At my feet
26. "Keats as a poet is abundantly and enchantingly sensuous" - who says this
- Matthew Arnold
27. Most of the lines of this poem are written in
- Iambic Pentameter
28. The nightingale sings spontaneously welcoming the season of
- Summer
29. But in embalmed darkness, goes each
- Sweet
30. Lethe is the river of
- Forgetfulness